Findings: The Trajectory Against the Paris Targets

> Part of the Functional Series. This document answers the series' central question: what do the platform's trends say about progress towards the Paris targets? Each finding is bounded and points to its evidence. The platform's scenarios are illustrative, not forecasts of policy; where a conclusion depends on that, it says so.

Finding 5. The platform's pathways fall short of Paris-aligned pathways

Finding. By 2035, relative to 2019, the platform's CO_2 pathways reach **+16% (BAU), –5% (Moderate) and –31% (Aggressive)**. The IPCC's median pathways need **–37% for 2 °C and –65% for 1.5 °C**. Even the Aggressive scenario is above the 2 °C median in 2030, 2035 and 2040.

Evidence. Pathways §2; Targets §3.

Confidence. High that the *scenarios as defined* fall short (an arithmetic fact). Moderate for what that implies: the scenarios are constant-percentage cuts applied uniformly, and a different design could do better.

Does not say. That Paris-aligned pathways are impossible, or that the true path will look like any of the three scenarios.

Finding 6. The required pace is well beyond anything in the record since 1960

Finding. From the 2024 level, a constant cut of about **4.6% a year** would follow the 2 °C median CO_2 pathway to 2035–2040, and about **9–11% a year** the 1.5 °C median. The largest annual fall since 1960 was **5.2% in 2020**, the pandemic year; the Aggressive scenario's net fall averages about 3.8% a year.

Evidence. Targets §2–3.

Confidence. High for the arithmetic; the IPCC ranges around each median are wide.

Does not say. That such cuts are infeasible. It says there is no precedent in the platform's record since 1960 apart from the 2020 pandemic, and that was a single year.

Finding 7. The remaining 1.5 °C carbon budget is almost spent

Finding. The two current assessments put the 50%-likelihood budget for 1.5 °C at **130 $GtCO_2$ (Forster et al.) or 170 $GtCO_2$ (Global Carbon Budget)** from the start of 2026: **three to four years** at the 2025 emissions rate of about 42 $GtCO_2$ a year. In the platform's scenarios the budget is used up between **2028 and 2030**, whichever estimate is used and whichever scenario. The 2 °C budget (about 1,050 $GtCO_2$) lasts beyond 2040 in all three scenarios.

Evidence. Pathways §3; Targets §4.

Confidence. Moderate to high. The two assessments differ by 40 $GtCO_2$ and the platform's crossing years come out slightly early (its accounting runs about 1.3 $GtCO_2$ a year above the budgets' basis), but a one-year shift does not change the conclusion.

Does not say. That warming reaches 1.5 °C the day the budget runs out. The budgets cover only the CO_2–warming uncertainty and assume a further 0.10 °C of non-CO_2 warming; the platform's own temperature level reaches 1.5 °C in 2033–2034, later than the budget, for that specific reason.

Finding 8. The scenarios matter less by 2040 than the emissions already emitted

Finding. In 2040 the platform's implied warming differs by only **0.10 °C** between BAU (1.68 °C) and Aggressive (1.58 °C), though annual emissions differ by about 2.2 times. Most (78–83%) of the 2040 level is warming already observed by 2024.

Evidence. Scenarios §5.

Confidence. Moderate. The bands cover slope uncertainty only, and the platform's rate of warming (about 0.23 °C a decade) is below Forster et al.'s 0.27, so it likely understates near-term warming.

Does not say. That mitigation does not matter. The gap widens every year the pathways stay apart (about 0.025 °C by 2032, 0.10 °C by 2040).

Finding 9. Pledges and policies are not yet on a Paris-aligned path

Finding. UNEP estimates that full implementation of the 2035 NDCs would cut emissions by about **12% (unconditional) to 15% (conditional)** from 2019, against **35% for 2 °C and 55% for 1.5 °C**. Projected warming this century is **2.3–2.5 °C** if all NDCs are fully implemented, and up to **2.8 °C** on current policies (UNEP); the Climate Action Tracker puts both at 2.6 °C and its optimistic scenario at 1.9 °C. By the Paris cycle, only 64 Parties covering 63% of emissions had submitted or announced new NDCs by 30 September 2025.

Evidence. Pathways §4; Country NDCs §4.

Confidence. Moderate. These are other organisations' projections, with their own ranges, and they moved by 0.1 °C or more between editions for methodological reasons.

Does not say. That pledges and policies cannot improve. The Agreement's design assumes they ratchet upward at each five-year round, and the next formal checkpoint is the 2028 global stocktake.

Where the platform's evidence ends

Question	What the platform can support	What needs other evidence
Are emissions falling?	Observed to 2024: not yet	What policies will do next
Is the 1.5 °C limit still within reach?	The budget is nearly spent; overshoot is likely on these pathways	Whether large removals or very rapid cuts will follow
What will warming be in 2100?	Nothing: the horizon is 2040	The published outlooks (1.9–3.2 °C by 2100, depending on assumptions)
Which countries will meet their NDCs?	Direction and distance, on gross emissions	UNEP's policy-based assessment (Country NDCs)

See also

- Where Things Stand
- Country Differences
- Caveats and Reading Guide